

PROJECT CHARTER

THE SIMS PRIORITY GAP

Did The Sims 4 Forget How to Simulate Life?

10+ Years of Data Says Yes

Full Project Available on [GitHub](#) | Dashboard Available on [Tableau](#)

Author	Project Type	Tools	Completion Date
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1. PROBLEM OVERVIEW

The gaming community has long felt that EA is more interested in selling new hairstyles and furniture packs than actually improving or expanding the game's simulation. By analyzing 10+ years of The Sims 4 releases, I will show how the product has shifted from a functional life simulation to an aesthetic-focused storefront, particularly after the introduction of Kits in 2021.

2. PROBLEM STATEMENT

EA positions The Sims 4 as a 'life simulation' game. However, when most of the content investment over a decade goes into aesthetics (new clothing, hairstyles, furniture packs, and build items) rather than simulation depth (open world, a colour wheel, drivable cars, and more complex life-stage mechanics), it creates a measurable gap between the brand positioning and the business reality. This project uses data to show that EA's content model shifted toward high-volume aesthetic items, particularly after the introduction of Kits in 2021.

3. CENTRAL QUESTION

Across 98 paid DLC packs released between 2014 and 2026, what proportion of The Sims 4's paid content was Simulation-Rich versus Aesthetic, and how did that proportion change over time?

4. OBJECTIVES

- **Content Categorization:** Categorize every Sims 4 DLC release as either Aesthetic (visual) or Simulation-Rich (functional) content.

- **Prove the Pattern:** Show how the content balance shifted over time, specifically how the introduction of Kits in 2021 marked the turning point where Aesthetic content dominated releases.
- **Retail Value Analysis:** Calculate the cumulative retail value (based on launch prices) for each content category.
- **Measure the Wait Time:** Identify top community-requested simulation features and measure how long they have gone unaddressed.
- **Compare Competitors:** Compare The Sims 4's features against The Sims 3 and newer competitors to find out whether the features missing from The Sims 4 are actually too difficult to build, or whether other games are already doing them. If a competitor has a feature that The Sims 4 is missing, it suggests EA made a choice, it was unlikely to be a technical limitation.
- **Quantify the Content:** Show what proportion of 10+ years of paid content is surface-level aesthetic versus content that actually deepens the simulation.
- **Establish the Critique:** Use data to show how a monetization model that prioritizes volume of cheap content over meaningful gameplay investment can hollow out a game's core identity over time.
- **Tell the Story:** Present findings in a Tableau Public dashboard that is clear enough for everyone to understand.

5. SCOPE

Scope	Details
In Scope	All 98 DLC packs (2014- March 2026): Expansion Packs, Game Packs, Stuff Packs, Kits
In Scope	Community-requested features log (EA Forums, Reddit, YouTube Reviews & Comments, Blogs)
In Scope	Competitor feature comparison: 23 features across 6 game versions
Out of Scope	Free base game updates and patches
Out of Scope	Mods, custom content, and third-party additions
Out of Scope	Player sentiment analysis or survey data

Out of Scope	EA's actual sales figures (not publicly disclosed)
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6. DATA SOURCES

Dataset	Source	Records
DLC Master Log	EA Store, Sims Wiki	98 packs plus 1 base game row
Community-Requested Features Log	EA forums, r/Sims4, r/thesims, YouTube reviews and comments	17 features
Feature Comparison	Official game pages, gaming press	138 rows (23 features across 6 game versions)

7. TOOLS & TECHNOLOGIES

Purpose	Tool
Data Collection	Manual research using Sims Wiki, EA Store, EA forums, Reddit, and YouTube
Data Storage and Analysis	Microsoft Excel (COUNTIFS, SUMIFS, IFERROR, Pivot Tables, Slicers, Conditional Formatting)
Visualization	Tableau Public: 7 visualizations across 7 chart types
Documentation	Microsoft Word

8. DELIVERABLES

Deliverable	Location
DLC Master Log and Analysis Sheets	GitHub
Seven-chart Interactive Dashboard	Live Tableau URL
Executive Summary	GitHub
Project Report	GitHub
Project Charter	GitHub
GitHub README	GitHub

9. CLASSIFICATION RUBRIC

Classification	Definition	Rule
Simulation-Rich	A pack whose primary purpose is to introduce a new gameplay system, mechanic, life stage, career with genuine depth, or world feature that changes how the game functions.	If the pack introduces something that changes what a Sim can do or experience in a meaningful way, it is Simulation-Rich.
Aesthetic	A pack whose primary purpose is to add visual content like clothing, furniture, décor, or build objects, without introducing a new gameplay system, mechanic, or simulation feature.	If removing all new items would leave the game playing identically, it is Aesthetic.

10. ASSUMPTIONS & LIMITATIONS

- **Manual Entry:** Data Accuracy depends on the completeness of community wikis and store listings.
- **Pricing:** All calculations are USD launch prices. Discounts and regional pricing are excluded.
- **Classification:** The 'Aesthetic vs. Simulation-Rich' split involves analyst judgement. Criteria are documented in the Excel Workbook for transparency. Also, some packs were difficult to classify as Aesthetic or Simulation-Rich. These judgement calls are explained in the Project Report methodology.
- **Retail Value:** All figures are based on launch prices only. EA does not disclose actual sales data.
- **Competitor data:** inZOI and Paralives are not fully released. Their features may change before or after full launch.

- ***Community request dates:*** Based on the oldest verified sources found during research. Players may have been requesting some features earlier than what I was able to document.

11. SUCCESS CRITERIA

- All 98 packs classified with no blank cells in Content Category column.
- Excel workbook passes all checks: total packs equal 98, total DLC retail value equals \$1,508.02.
- Tableau dashboard published and accessible.
- A recruiter with no gaming background can read the Executive Summary and understand the core findings in under two minutes.
- All written documents are consistent; figures, terminology, and findings match across every document.